

THE PACT-WRIGHT'S LEASH

Letters Discovered in a Sealed Thepyrgosi Vault

BETWEEN BORTE OF THE VIOLET STEPPE
AND SCHOLAR-MONK KAELEN OF VARNEK KARN

Transcribed by Daeyas the Dreamer
Archivist of the Unfinished Index



The bone-singer does not summon. She listens.

The drum is not a call. It is an invitation.

If the dead do not answer, she does not knock again.

Knocking is rude. Rudeness is a debt.

— Borte of the Violet Steppe

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The Dreamer's Account

THE following correspondence was found in a lead-lined strongbox behind a false wall in the sub-basement of the Synod's Archivolt. The box bore no seal—only a single red thread knotted eight times. The ninth knot was cut.

Scholar-Monk Kaelen was reported missing in 861 AR. No body was found. Borte of the Violet Steppe appears in no census, no customs ledger, no Inquisition record. The Dreamer, who transcribed these letters at the request of the Grey Wanderer, has since vanished from their rooms at the Amber Gate. The Wanderer says they are *merely travelling*. The Wanderer is not a reliable witness.

These letters are presented as found. The Archivist's notes are in brackets. The margins contain commentary from the Grey Wanderer, Saikou Ira, and Lerris Fenwood—added later, in different hands, in different inks. The ninth knot is not tied. It is left loose. It is the space where the Hollow sits when we negotiate. The Hollow is not a spirit. It is not a patron. It is the *attention* that fills the gap when a debt is forgotten.



Letter One: The Weight of Binding



Undated. No seal.

Written on vellum pressed between funerary pages.



KAELEN

Scholar-Monk of Varnek Karn

Borte—

You will not remember me. We met at the dust market outside Midh Ahkaz, seven years ago. You were selling a drum made from the hide of a horse that had thrown you. I was buying—not the drum, but the story. You charged me a cup of salt and a memory. I paid in the memory of my grandmother's face. You said it was a fair price. I have not forgotten her face since.

I write from Thepyrgos, studying the Varnek Karn fragments. The monks think I am a historian. I am a death-negotiator without a leash, a pact-wright without a drum.

You taught me: *"The straight road is a lie. The wise follow the bent twig."* I thought you spoke of the steppe. You spoke of binding.

The leash is not a rope. It is a promise with teeth. — The Grey Wanderer[-0.2cm]

I have found a fragment—a page of Varnek Karn's original testament, written in ash and salt water. It reads:

"The dead do not forget. They do not forgive. But they will negotiate—if the witness is true and the price is named."

The marginal note, in a different hand:

"The ninth knot is not a knot. It is the space between. Borte knows this. Ask her why she does not cut it."

How do they know your name? How do they know about the ninth knot?

— Kaelen

The Tulkani courier was found at a crossroads, still holding the letter. She had forgotten why she was there. The letter was warm. — The Grey Wanderer[-0.2cm]



The Pact Clock

The pact-wright does not command the dead. She negotiates. The leash is not a rope; it is a promise with teeth.

A pact-wright tracks a **Pact Clock** for each bound spirit:

Table 2.1: Pact Clock States

Segments	State	Effect
0	Unbound	Spirit is free.
1-2	Indebted	One service per segment.
3-4	Bonded	Two services; independent action.
5-6	Oath-Bound	Bound until debt is paid.

Ticking: +1 per service, +2 acting against nature, +1 crossing [WARD], +1 per extra scene manifested.

Clearing: -1 fulfilling a promise, -2 witnessed atonement, -3 sacrificing a memory or name.

When the clock fills (6 segments), the spirit acts once according to its nature—often destructively—then departs. The pact-wright gains 1 Corruption.

Letter Two: The Drum and the Leash



Written on scrap leather. No date.

Ink is lamp-black and blood.



BORTE

of the Violet Steppe

Kaelen—

You paid too much for the story. A grandmother's face is worth more than a cup of salt. But you offered, and I accepted, and the debt is paid. That is the law. The law is final.

The ninth knot is not tied. It is left loose. It is the space where the Hollow sits when we negotiate. The Hollow is the *attention* that fills the gap when a debt is forgotten.

I interviewed a Chain-Lantern who attended Sister Alva's execution. The fire would not take her. When the ashes cooled, they found a single unburned thread. The ninth knot. — Saikou Ira[-0.2cm]

My grandmother taught me:

"The dead do not forget. They do not forgive. But they will bargain—if you bring a witness and you do not lie. The witness is for you. So you remember what you promised."

The ninth knot is not mine to cut. It belongs to the Hollow. When the Hollow is ready to collect, it will cut the knot itself.

Do not write again. The Tulkani courier you sent was found at a crossroads. She remembered only that she had been carrying a letter. She did not know why.

— Borte

The Hollow takes the memory of the messenger as a toll. Borte knows this. She did not warn Kaelen. That is also a debt. — Saikou Ira[-0.2cm]



The Three Traditions

3.0.1 *The Bone-Singer (Ykrul)*

The Ykrul do not bind spirits. They *invite* them. The drum is the focus—made from the hide of the specific creature or ancestor being called.

The drum is not a tool. It is a throat. When I beat it, the dead speak through me. The silence between beats is the question. —

Borte[-0.2cm]

Signature Rite: The Drum-Heart

Once per scene, beat a drum as an action. Roll Spirit + Performance (DV 3). On a hit, all spirits within Near gain [ATTENTIVE]—they answer one question truthfully. On a miss, they ask a question; answer truthfully or mark 1 Corruption.

Taboo: Never beat a drum made from a horse you did not kill yourself. The horse's ghost will remember.

3.0.2 *The Death-Negotiator (Varnek Karn)*

Varnek Karn dwells between life and death. His worshippers *audit* the dead, carrying a leash of bone and skin.

Signature Rite: The Final Testament

When a creature dies within Near, record its last words. The spirit becomes bound to the recording. Later, negotiate as if it were present.

Taboo: Never record a death you did not witness. Varnek Karn knows when you lie. Interest is paid in memory.

3.0.3 *The Chained (Malachai's Desperate)*

Some are chosen by Malachai, who offers cursed gifts to those with nothing left to lose. They bind through *debt*.

Signature Rite: The Honeyed Binding

Once per session, offer a spirit a gift. It tests Resolve (DV 4) or accepts a Debt Clock [4]. When the clock fills, demand one service.

Taboo: Never offer a gift you cannot afford to lose. Malachai does not accept returns.

Letter Three: The Key and the Knot



*Written on a torn funerary page.
Ink smeared. Handwriting less careful.*



KAELEN
Scholar-Monk of Varnek Karn

Borte—

I am afraid. I have sat with the dying for forty years. I have never been afraid. I am afraid now.

The fragment is not a fragment. It is a *key*. There are seven other pages. Together, they form a complete contract. A complete debt.

The marginal note mentioning your name was written by a woman named Sister Alva. She was a Daughter of the Unbroken Cord. Executed in 812 AR.

Sister Alva was not executed. She was woven into the Cord. Borte's ninth knot is a thread from Alva's own shroud. — Lerris Fenwood[-0.2cm]

She has been dead forty-nine years.

Her note knew your name before you were born.

What are you, Borte? Who tied your ninth knot?

— Kaelen



The Leash

The leash is the pact-wright's signature tool—a physical cord that binds a spirit to service. Each leash has:

- **Eight visible knots** marking services owed
- **A ninth space** where the Hollow watches
- **A witness** who saw the binding

A leash can be:

- **Tied** to bind a new spirit
- **Knot added** when a service is performed
- **Loosened** when a debt is paid
- **Cut** only by the Hollow, or by the pact-wright accepting the spirit's resentment as Corruption

Material Components

Material	Use
Horsehair	Binding animal spirits and ancestors
Silk	Binding fae and threshold spirits
Lamp-wick	Binding spirits of fire and light
Grave-thread	Binding the anchored dead
Iron wire	Binding demons and the chained

Letter Four: The Thread That Burned



No salutation. Written on bark.

Ink is red.



BORTE

of the Violet Steppe

Sister Alva was my grandmother.

She did not hollow children. She *saved* them. The children she hollowed were already dead. She gave them a second life—without breath, without heartbeat. They became the Hollowed. They witness the leash. They do not forget.

I have seen the Hollowed. They stand in corners, unblinking. Their eyes are milk-white. I have never stayed in a room with one longer than I had to. — Saikou Ira[-0.2cm]

She was executed because the Chain-Lanterns did not understand the difference between hollowing the dead and hollowing the living. They do not understand that the ninth knot is not a threat. It is a *promise*.

She tied my knot the night before they burned her. She said: *“This knot is for the Hollow. When it cuts, you will know. Until then, you are free.”*

I am not free. The knot is a leash. The Hollow holds it. I am the horse that threw me, still running, still waiting.

The next messenger you send will not forget. They will remember everything. The Hollow will take them whole.

— Borte



The Hollowed

The Hollowed are not familiars. They are witnesses—creatures (or children) who died and were returned, their hearts replaced with knotted thread and ash.

Traits

- **Milk-white eyes** that never close
- **No heartbeat** and no breath
- **Perfect memory** of every debt they witness
- **Silence** — they do not speak, but sometimes weep blood when a debt comes due

Mechanics

A pact-wright bonded to the High Mother (or to Borte's tradition) may receive a Hollowed instead of a familiar. The Hollowed:

- Counts as a witness for all pact rites
- Cannot be harmed by mundane means (it is already dead)
- Attracts suspicion from Chain-Lanterns and witch-hunters (Exposure +1 in any scene where it is noticed)
- Will not enter consecrated ground without the pact-wright's permission

The Kettle

Each coven of Daughters keeps a Kettle—a brass vessel where the hearts of the Hollowed are preserved. The hearts beat slowly, in unison, recording every debt the Hollowed have witnessed. A pact-wright may consult the Kettle to ask one question about any witnessed oath; the Kettle answers in heartbeats (one for yes, two for no, three for “the debt is not yet due”).

Letter Five: The Catacombs



Written on vellum, dampened and dried repeatedly.

Ink blurred.



KAELEN

Scholar-Monk of Varnek Karn

Borte—

I am going to the catacombs beneath Zahk'Kozahn. The seventh page is there. I will have eight of nine. The ninth page is missing. I suspect you know where it is.

I am not writing to ask for it. I am writing to say goodbye.

I have forgotten my mother's face. I have forgotten the taste of bread. I remember you. I remember the dust market. I remember the price.

If I do not return, tell the Hollow that I paid my debt.

— Kaelen

Kaelen did not return. The Archivolt found his leash in a sealed chamber, surrounded by eight candles. Nine candle stubs. One extinguished by a hand that left no fingerprint. — The Grey Wanderer[-0.2cm]



Spirits of the Leash

Wolf-Ancestor (Ykrul)

Nature: Ancestral, protective, prideful. **Appearance:** Grey wolf the size of a pony, eyes reflecting scenes from the summoner's childhood. **Services:** Tracking, guarding, teaching forgotten battle-songs. **Price:** The summoner must uphold the honor of the clan. **Pact Clock:** 2/6 (indebted)

The wolf does not forgive cowardice. It watches. It waits. It remembers. — Borte[-0.2cm]

The Drowned Mutineer (Zakov)

Nature: Vengeful dead, confused, bitter. **Appearance:** Bloated figure in rotting finery, halo of salt-crusted coins. **Services:** Ship sabotage, whispering secrets, cursing cargo. **Price:** A promise of vengeance against the

living. **Pact Clock:** 3/6 (bonded)

The Vein-Serpent (Aeler)

Nature: Indigenous, mineral, slow-witted. **Appearance:** Serpent of polished copper and malachite. **Services:** Locating ore, stabilizing tunnels, collapsing fortifications. **Price:** For every ounce taken, an ounce of mortar laid. **Pact Clock:** 1/6 (unbound)

The Lamp-Wight (Thepyrgos)

Nature: Tower ghost, bound to lighthouse or beacon. **Appearance:** Translucent keeper's uniform, lantern casting no light. **Services:** Reading coded signals, warning of incoming ships, revealing lies. **Price:** Keep a lamp lit in its tower one night each year. **Pact Clock:** 2/6 (indebted)

The Hearth-Bound (Aelaerem)

Nature: Ancestral, domestic, protective. **Appearance:** Faint figure in apron or smock, smelling of bread and woodsmoke. **Services:** Protecting a household, warding against nightmares, finding lost objects. **Price:** A cup of milk left on the hearth each night. **Pact Clock:** 1/6 (unbound—it may leave if neglected)

The Gallows-Shade (Ecktoria)

Nature: Wrongful execution, seeking justice. **Appearance:** Figure in rope-burned grey, neck bent at an unnatural angle. **Services:** Revealing lies, frightening the guilty, witnessing confessions. **Price:** Speak the name of its accuser aloud. **Pact Clock:** 4/6 (oath-bound—dangerous if ignored)

The Frost-Wight (Linn)

Nature: Drowned sailor, preserved in ice. **Appearance:** Figure of frost and brine, breath visible in warm rooms. **Services:** Calming storms, finding safe passage, preserving food. **Price:** A libation of fresh water poured into the sea. **Pact Clock:** 2/6 (indebted)

The Thorn-Courtier (Aelinnel)

Nature: Fae bound by broken courtesy. **Appearance:** Masked figure in leaves and law, voice like rustling paper. **Services:** Negotiating with other fae, revealing omissions in contracts, opening threshold doors. **Price:** Never speak its name aloud. **Pact Clock:** 3/6 (bonded—will twist words if possible)

Letter Six: Found in Kaelen's Leash, Unsent



*Written in the same hand, never sealed.
Folded, not creased—held a long time without closing.*



KAELEN
Scholar-Monk of Varnek Karn

Borte—

I found the seventh page. Misfiled under “Heretical Testimonies.” It reads:

“The ninth page was never written. It is left blank for the debtor’s name. When the name is written, the debt is paid. The debtor becomes the Hollow’s witness. The witness becomes the Hollow’s voice. The voice is silence.”

My name is not on the ninth page. It is blank.

I am going to write your name.

*The ninth page is not blank. The name written there is not Borte’s. It is Kaelen’s. He wrote his own name. He did not know.
The ink was invisible. — Lerris Fenwood[-0.2cm]*

I am not doing this to hurt you. I am doing this because you are already the Hollow’s witness. Now it will be witnessed. Recorded. Final.

Forgive me.

— Kaelen



The Ninth Page

The Varnek Karn testament is nine pages. Eight are written. The ninth is blank.

The Rite of the Final Name

When a pact-wright writes a name on the ninth page, that person becomes the Hollow’s witness. They cannot be forgotten. They cannot be recorded. Their name exists only in the space between the eighth page and the ninth.

Mechanics:

- The named person gains [UNRECORDED]—they appear in no written record for one year
- They may not swear binding oaths (the Hollow is the only witness)
- They may not own property (titles cannot hold)
- Once per session, they may ask the Hollow one question; the answer is always a single word, and the Hollow will collect a memory as interest

Removing the Name: Only the pact-wright who wrote it may erase it, and only by sacrificing a memory of equal weight to the debt.

Afterword: The Dreamer's Note

I TRANSCRIBED these letters at the request of the Grey Wanderer. I did not ask why.

Borte came to Thepyrgos three days after I finished. A horse followed her—a grey mare with eyes like dust. The horse made no sound. Its hooves left no prints.

She read the letters in silence. Then she tied a knot in red thread. The ninth knot. She cut it. The thread fell.

She said: *"The debt is paid."*

Then she left. The horse followed.

The Dreamer vanished three days later. Their rooms were empty. The thread was gone. On the floor, in dust that had not been there before, were hoofprints. They led to the door. Then they stopped. — The Grey Wanderer[-0.2cm]

The hoofprints continued on the ceiling. The Dreamer followed them. I do not know where. — Saikou Ira[-0.2cm]

The ninth knot is not cut. It was always tied. The Hollow does not release debtors. It only changes their interest rate. — Lerris Fenwood[-0.2cm]

— Daeyas the Dreamer



Part I

Compendium of Spirits

The Bound and the Hungry

THIS compendium catalogs spirits suitable for binding by pact-wrights. Each entry includes the spirit's nature, appearance, typical services, price, and starting Pact Clock. The entries are drawn from Borte's scattered notes and Kaelen's unfinished commentary.

9.1 Ancestral Spirits

9.1.1 Hearth-Bound (Aelaerem)

Nature: Ancestral, domestic, protective. Grandparents or parents who refuse to depart until their descendants flourish.

Appearance: Faint figure in apron or smock, smelling of bread and woodsmoke. Leaves no footprints.

Services: Protecting a household, warding against nightmares, finding lost objects, keeping milk from souring.

Price: A cup of milk left on the hearth each night, and a story told before bed.

Pact Clock: 1/6 (unbound—may leave if neglected)

Cultural Note: The Vilikari call them the Warm-Hand. The Aelaerem leave them the first cup of tea.

9.1.2 Wolf-Ancestor (Ykrul)

Nature: Ancestral, protective, prideful. A specific ancestor who died defending the clan.

Appearance: Grey wolf the size of a pony, eyes reflecting scenes from the summoner's childhood. Fur smells of dry grass and iron.

Services: Tracking across any terrain, guarding camps, teaching forgotten battle-songs, sensing oath-breakers.

Price: The summoner must uphold the honor of the clan. Any cowardice breaks the bond immediately.

Pact Clock: 2/6 (indebted)

The wolf does not forgive cowardice. It watches. It waits. It remembers. — Borte[-0.2cm]

9.1.3 Gallows-Shade (Ecktoria)

Nature: Wrongful execution, seeking justice or vengeance.

Appearance: Figure in rope-burned grey, neck bent at an unnatural angle. Carries a noose that tightens when lies are spoken.

Services: Revealing lies, frightening the guilty, witnessing confessions, loosening knots.

Price: Speak the name of its accuser aloud, in public, with witnesses.

Pact Clock: 4/6 (oath-bound—dangerous if ignored)

9.2 *Elemental and Indigenous Spirits*

9.2.1 *Vein-Serpent (Aeler)*

Nature: Indigenous, mineral, slow-witted. The mountain's blood given form.

Appearance: Serpent of polished copper and malachite, slithering through stone as if it were water. Scales warm to the touch.

Services: Locating veins of ore, stabilizing tunnels, collapsing enemy fortifications, warning of earthquakes (hums through bedrock three days in advance).

Price: For every ounce of ore taken, an ounce of mortar must be laid. The stone must be maintained.

Pact Clock: 1/6 (unbound)

The Aeler do not kill Vein-Serpents. They hire them. The serpent is paid in copper dust and silence. — Kaelen[-0.2cm]

9.2.2 *Frost-Wight (Linn)*

Nature: Drowned sailor, preserved in ice. Bound to a ship or a stretch of coast.

Appearance: Figure of frost and brine, breath visible in warm rooms. Clothes frozen solid; hair like icicles.

Services: Calming storms, finding safe passage through ice, preserving food from rot, speaking with seabirds.

Price: A libation of fresh water poured into the sea at each new moon.

Pact Clock: 2/6 (indebted)

9.2.3 *Dust-Djanni (Fhara)*

Nature: Desert spirit, old as the erg. Not hostile, but never generous.

Appearance: Column of dust shaped like a robed figure, eyes of polished amber.

Services: Finding water, hiding tracks, creating sandstorms, revealing oases.

Price: A song sung at noon, with no audience but the sun.

Pact Clock: 2/6 (indebted)

9.3 *The Violent and the Vengeful*

9.3.1 *The Drowned Mutineer (Zakov)*

Nature: Vengeful dead, confused, bitter. Died by betrayal, now seeks the betrayer's bloodline.

Appearance: Bloated figure in rotting finery, surrounded by a halo of salt-crusted coins. Skin is grey; eyes are black.

Services: Sabotage of ships, whispering secrets into sleeping ears, cursing cargo to spoil, revealing mutinies before they happen.

Price: A promise of vengeance against the living. The summoner must carry the mutineer's grudge as their own.

Pact Clock: 3/6 (bonded—will turn on a weak summoner)

9.3.2 *The Red Jester (Silkstrand)*

Nature: A hanged fool who laughs at oaths. Dangerous and unpredictable.

Appearance: Masked figure in motley, bells on every limb. The bells ring when a promise is broken nearby.

Services: Causing distractions, sabotaging contracts, revealing hypocrisy, making guards forget their orders.

Price: A genuine laugh—not forced, not performative. The Jester will know the difference.

Pact Clock: 4/6 (oath-bound—will betray for a better joke)

9.3.3 *The Broken-Knight (Vhasia)*

Nature: A knight who broke an oath of fealty and was executed. Seeks to restore honor.

Appearance: Armor rusted shut, visor down. Cannot open it. Speaks through the rust.

Services: Fighting as a spectral ally, holding a threshold, testing the honor of others, carrying messages through enemy lines.

Price: A witness to its deathbed confession. The witness must speak the knight's name at the site of its execution.

Pact Clock: 3/6 (bonded)

9.4 *Threshold and Fae Spirits*9.4.1 *Lamp-Wight (Thepyrgos)*

Nature: Tower ghost, bound to a lighthouse or beacon. Dutiful, lonely, precise.

Appearance: Translucent figure in keeper's uniform, carrying a lantern that casts no light. The lantern is cold.

Services: Reading coded signals, warning of incoming ships, revealing lies told in its presence, keeping a flame lit against wind.

Price: Keep a lamp lit in its tower one night each year. The lamp must be lit by your hand.

Pact Clock: 2/6 (indebted)

9.4.2 *Thorn-Courtier (Aelinnel)*

Nature: Fae bound by broken courtesy. A courtier of the Lady of Thorns, exiled for a misstep.

Appearance: Masked figure in leaves and law, voice like rustling paper. Never shows its face.

Services: Negotiating with other fae, revealing omissions in contracts, opening threshold doors, translating the old tongue.

Price: Never speak its name aloud. If you do, it will demand a service of equal weight.

Pact Clock: 3/6 (bonded—will twist words if possible)

9.4.3 *The Silent Step (Ikasha)*

Nature: A shadow that learned to walk. Not dead, not alive—simply unnoticed.

Appearance: A patch of darkness that moves against the light. No features, no sound.

Services: Carrying whispers, hiding objects, walking through locked doors, forgetting debts (on behalf of others).

Price: A secret you have never told anyone. The Silent Step will not repeat it—but it will know.

Pact Clock: 1/6 (unbound—will leave if betrayed)

9.5 *Aeler Stone-Sleepers*

9.5.1 *Bell-Wight*

Nature: A miner who died counting breaths. Now counts everything.

Appearance: Dwarven figure in miner's gear, carrying a bell that never rings.

Services: Counting inventory, detecting structural flaws, warning of bad air, finding lost tools.

Price: Never count to nine in its presence. It will stop you.

Pact Clock: 1/6 (unbound)

9.5.2 *Keystone-Keeper*

Nature: An engineer who sealed a tunnel and was sealed inside.

Appearance: Spectral figure in mason's apron, hands covered in stone-dust that does not wash off.

Services: Sealing doors, reading keystone clauses, detecting forgeries, stabilizing load-bearing walls.

Price: A repair year—one year of maintaining the tunnel where it died.

Pact Clock: 4/6 (oath-bound)

Part II

Colophon

The Leash Closes

*These letters were returned to the lead-lined strongbox
and resealed with a new red thread—
eight knots, the ninth left loose.*

*The box was returned to the Archivolt's sub-basement.
The Grey Wanderer holds the key.
The Wanderer says the key is a name.
The Wanderer will not say whose.*

*The Dreamer has not been found.
The horse has not been seen.*

*Borte of the Violet Steppe appears in no record—
except this one, and the one that was written in Kaelen's leash,
and the one that was whispered at a crossroads,
under a lamp that should have gone out but did not.*

*The leash has two ends.
The Hollow holds both.*

*— The Grey Wanderer
at the Dusty Page,
under the ninth bell (which did not ring)*



The ink is ash and blood. The ninth page is blank.
The knot is not cut. The debt is not closed. The horse is still running.